

WE CAN'T KEEP EVERYTHING FOREVER

A LANDSCAPE ANALYSIS OF DATA RETENTION IN U.S. DATA REPOSITORIES

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BACKGROUND & MOTIVATION

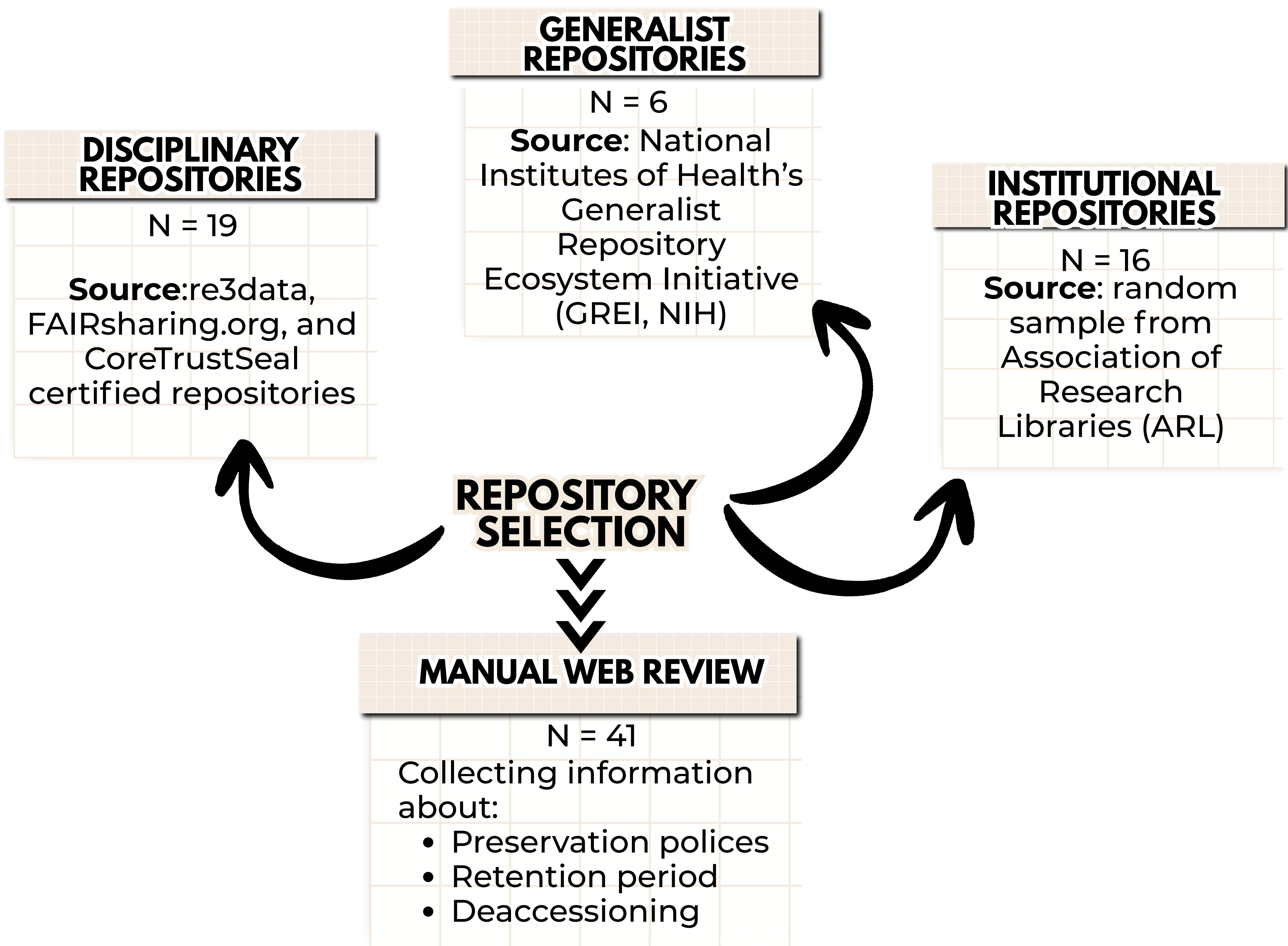
- Research data continue to grow in size, complexity, and technical dependencies.
- More repositories are available than ever before (e.g., institutional, disciplinary, and generalist).
- Repository retention and deaccessioning practices remain unclear.



Our goal: examine current repository policies and retention practices.

OUR METHODOLOGY

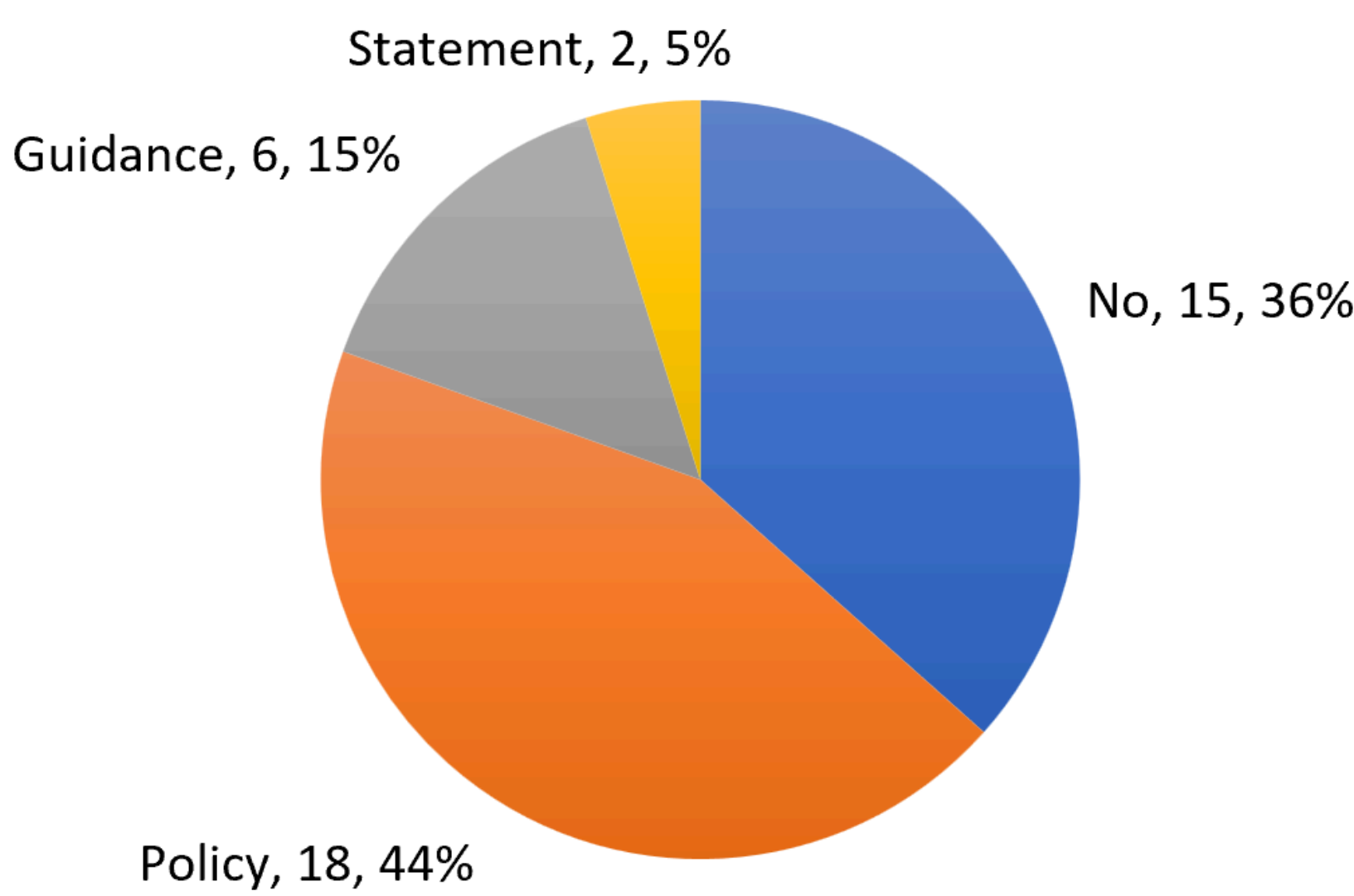
- Web-based reviewed publicly available repository information.



WHAT WE LEARNED

1) Preservation Policies & Guidance (N = 41)

- **63%** provided either a preservation **policy** or **guidance**.
- **Less than half** (44%) had a **formal preservation policy**.



2) Retention and Review (N = 26)

- **38%** repositories **specify a retention period**.
- The most common reported **retention commitment** is **10 years**.
- **62%** repositories **promise either indefinite or unspecified retention**.

3) Preservation Commitments

- **85%** repositories promise **bit-level preservation**.
- Only **2 repositories** mention **file migration**.
- In most cases, **files are preserved as deposited**, with little indication of ongoing format management.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Formal preservation policies are not yet the norm.
- Retention policies are often vague.
- Deaccessioning is typically framed as legal takedown rather than active collection management.

FUTURE DIRECTIONS

- Expand the study through broader repository sampling
- Conduct in-depth interview with repositories currently deaccessioning datasets.
- Collaborate with researchers and domain experts to develop more effective, discipline-specific preservation and review practices.

Without defined retention policies, repositories risk retaining unusable data indefinitely or removing valuable data without transparent, consistent criteria.



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